

NCIA Request for Information (RFI)



ISR COLLECTION ORCHESTRATION SERVICE

RFI-186962-APSS_ICOS

NCIA/ACQ/2026/06969
Wednesday, 01 April 2026

NCIA Request for Information (RFI)

**To: Industry Partners
Distribution List**

1. The NATO Communications and Information Agency (NCIA) is conducting market research to identify qualified vendors and gather input on potential solutions to support the ability of Allied Command Operations (ACO) to orchestrate Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance (ISR) data procured or accessed on the unclassified network. We hereby issue the attached Request for Information (RFI) RFI-186962-APSS_ICOS to solicit feedback from capable and interested industry partners.
2. This RFI is issued for planning purposes only and is not a request for bids. It is part of NCIA's effort to ensure it has a clear understanding of the marketplace, available capabilities, and potential acquisition strategies to deliver ACO capabilities as Alliance Persistent Surveillance from Space (APSS) moves towards Full Operational Capability (FOC), supported through the Intel and ISR Functional Services Data Management Project.
3. We value your insight and invite you to:
 - a. Provide a response to the information requested at Annex A.
 - b. Share relevant corporate capabilities and experience;
 - c. Review and comment on our draft requirements (Annex B) with a view to providing recommendations for improving performance outcomes, competition, effectiveness and efficiency; and identifying any risks or concerns that should be considered during planning.
 - d. Provide your responses to the RFI questions in Annex C.
4. Submission instructions and additional details can be found in the enclosure to this RFI.
5. Only companies from a NATO member country can participate in or respond to this RFI (https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/nato_countries.htm).
6. Should you have any questions or need clarification, please contact Adrian Lita, Senior Contracting Officer (Consultant), at RFI-186962-APSS_ICOS@ncia.nato.int
7. We thank you in advance for your time and input, and we look forward to engaging with you as we shape this potential acquisition.
8. **Annexes:**
 - Request for Information at Annex A
 - High-Level Summary of Requirements at Annex B
 - RFI Questions at Annex C
 - Distribution List at Annex D

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REQUEST FOR INFORMATION

A. Introduction

1. The NATO Communications and Information Agency (NCIA) is conducting market research to identify potential sources and gather information regarding industry capabilities, through eliciting industry views on the envisioned services for the orchestration of unclassified ISR data outlined at Annex B - to inform the project requirements. This Request for Information (RFI) is issued solely for informational purposes and does not constitute a Request for Proposal (RFP), Request for Quotation (RFQ), or invitation for bid.

B. Purpose

1. The purpose of this RFI is to obtain input from industry to help inform the NCIA's acquisition planning. Responses to this RFI will assist in refining requirements, identifying capabilities, and shaping the strategy for any future solicitation.

C. Background

1. The Alliance Persistent Surveillance from Space (APSS) programme represents NATO's commitment to establish a persistent, federated space-based ISR capability through the Aquila virtual constellation, integrating national satellites, commercial providers, and publicly available data sources. As APSS transitions from Initial Operational Capability (IOC) toward Full Operational Capability (FOC), ACO and Nations require a unified service to orchestrate collection tasking, manage data ingest, and ensure timely exploitation of ISR data on unclassified networks.
2. NCIA seeks to provide collection managers within Allied Command Operations with a capability to search, order, manage, process, view and task Nationally, Commercially, and Publicly Available Information on the unclassified network.
3. This ISR Collection Orchestration Service will enable Collection managers to have a single-entry point to Commercial ISR providers on contract with NATO; nationally provided data from within the APSS Programme; and Publicly Available Information, supporting the ability to satisfy the Commander's critical intelligence requirements at the speed of relevance, whilst maintaining a stringent focus on security aspects.
4. The Service is envisaged to contain several key capabilities, including: access to data from desired (contracted and Publicly available) sources; the ability to understand collection opportunities; the ability to task data providers.
5. A High-Level Summary of the ISR Collection Orchestration Service requirements are contained within Annex B.
6. The RFI seeks to elicit the view of industry partners on the scope of the envisioned services and facilitate the Agency's insight into best-in-class industry solutions, including current market capabilities, and pricing models of Services offered.
7. A full list of questions that the Agency would like to canvass industry views on are contained within Annex C

D. Submission Instructions

1. Interested parties are invited to respond in accordance with the instructions below:

- a. Submit responses via the email address in section H no later than **12:00 hours Central European Time (CET) on 30 April 2026**.
- b. Responses should be submitted in PDF or Word format and must not exceed **10 pages**, including:
 - i. Responses to [Annex A](#), comments on [Annex B](#)
 - ii. Responses to the questions in [Annex C](#)

excluding:

 - i. Cover page
 - ii. Company brochures or product literature (if included)
 - iii. Attachments such as past performance references
- c. Use the following subject line for submission
 - i. "Response to RFI-186962-APSS_ICOS – [Company Name]"

E. Industry Engagement

1. The NCIA does not envisage conducting further industry engagement following the receipt of RFI responses.
2. However, should this approach change, further information on additional RFIs and/or Industry Day events will be published through the NCIA '[Current Opportunities](#)' page and distributed via the National Delegations, NATEXs, and Embassies.

F. Disclaimer

1. This RFI is for planning and informational purposes only and shall not be construed as a solicitation or obligation on the part of the NCIA. The NCIA does not intend to award a contract based on responses to this RFI. Respondents are solely responsible for all costs incurred in responding to this RFI. The NCIA will consider and analyse all information received from this RFI and may use these findings to develop a future solicitation. The NCIA will consider all responses as confidential commercial information and will protect it as such.
2. NCIA reserves the right, at any time, to cancel this informal market survey, partially or in its entirety. No legal liability on the part of NCIA for payment of any sort shall arise and in no event will a cause of action lie with any prospective participant for the recovery of any costs incurred in connection with the preparation of documentation or participation in response hereto. All effort initiated or undertaken by prospective informal market survey participants shall be done considering and accepting this fact.

G. Use of Information Provided through Responses

1. Confidentiality of Responses

The NCIA may incorporate industry comments and responses, in part or in whole, into a future release of a solicitation. Should respondents include proprietary data in their responses that they do not wish to be disclosed to the public for any purpose, or used by NCIA (except for internal evaluation purposes), they must:

a. Mark the title page with the following legend:

This document includes data that shall not be disclosed outside NATO and shall not be duplicated, used, or disclosed – in whole or in part – for any purpose other than for NCIA internal evaluation purposes, unless otherwise expressly authorised by [insert company name]. This restriction does not limit the NCIA's right to use information contained in this data without restriction if it is obtained from another source. The data subject to this restriction are contained in sheets [insert numbers or other identification of sheets]

b. Mark each sheet of data it wishes to restrict with the following legend:

Use or disclosure of data contained on this sheet is subject to the restriction on the title page of this document.

H. RFI Point of Contact

1. Adrian Lita – Senior Contracting Officer
2. [RFI-186962-APSS ICOS@ncia.nato.int](mailto:RFI-186962-APSS_ICOS@ncia.nato.int)

Annex A – Requested Information

1. Respondents are encouraged to provide the following information in their response:

a. Company Information

- i. Legal Business Name
- ii. Address
- iii. Website
- iv. Primary Point of Contact
- v. Email address
- vi. Size of organisation

b. Technical Capability

- i. Summary of relevant capabilities and past performance

c. Feedback and Recommendations

- i. Comments on the draft High-Level Summary of Requirements for ISR Collection Orchestration Service Capabilities (Annex B)
- ii. Responses to the RFI Questions in Annex C – RFI Questions
- iii. Innovations or alternatives
- iv. Rough Order Magnitude (ROM), including any assumptions upon which they are based

d. Questions or Concerns

- i. Risks, concerns, or barriers
- ii. Suggestions for risk mitigation or enhancing competition

Annex B – High-Level Summary of Requirements for the ISR Collection Orchestration Service

Note: This is a DRAFT and subject to change. The NCIA is seeking industry feedback.

1. Background

The NATO Communications and Information Agency (NCIA) aims to support the Collection Manager community by providing a capability to search, order, manage, process, view and task National, Commercial and Publicly Available information through the unclassified network. This ISR Collection Orchestration Service will enable collection managers to task and access the information required to satisfy the Commander's critical intelligence requirements at the speed of relevance.

To stay abreast of the rapid developments in data collection and analytics, NCIA requires a contractual mechanism that comprises of best-in-class industry solutions. The successful Contractor must offer the flexibility to access diverse data sources while maintaining a stringent focus on the security aspects.

2. Scope

The overall scope of the ISR Collection Orchestration Service can be split into four main areas:

a. Collection Opportunities

- i. NCIA requires the ability to understand collection opportunities available from commercial companies on contract with NCIA, and National capabilities that can be accessed via unclassified means.
- ii. This allows the User to be efficient in developing a Collection Plan, and presents the ability to understand collection gaps.
- iii. Additionally, it enables the User to optimise Collection Tasking.

b. Collection Tasking

- i. NCIA requires the ability to task commercial companies on contract with NCIA, and National capabilities, through a single platform.
- ii. This will ensure that Collection managers have a single platform rather than multiple entry points to commercial ISR.
- iii. The Collection Managers should be able to optimise tasking requirements depending upon the signature and location for collection.

c. Data Access

- i. The service will provide access to third-party services or data, both directly and through APIs.
- ii. The service will enable access to relevant and desired data from a wide range of sources including, but not limited to:
 - Open data from space
 - Commercial companies Archive data
 - Any relevant new and emerging data sources

d. Data Analytics

- i. The service will allow Collection managers to understand data usage through the visualisation of data metrics regarding data tasking, access and timings related to tasking, delivery and access.
- ii. The service will ensure that the data visualisation is able to be tailored by Collection managers to present data as required by the user.

e. Non-Functional Requirements

- i. To ensure Collection managers are able to effectively and securely use the ISR Collection Orchestration Service capabilities, tailored online training will be provided to both users and administrators.
- ii. Licensing must be scalable and flexible to meet changing operational requirements.
- iii. Any capability provided must be intuitive and be supported by robust customer service.
- iv. It must remain abreast of leading industry advancements in the collection, automation and processing of space based ISR.
- v. Any space based ISR data already procured by NATO shall be made available through the service.

3. Objectives

- a. The objective of the service envisioned is to provide Collection managers with advanced space based ISR collection and processing capabilities, including acquisition, discoverability and retrieval.
- b. The ISR Collection Orchestration Service must integrate with existing NATO capabilities.
- c. While providing these capabilities, the Agency intends to:
 - i. **Maximise** the participation of the space based ISR services market, as opposed to running its own platform.
 - ii. **Minimise** the number of separate contracts and limit custom development to focus on proven industry solutions.
 - iii. **Utilise** a primary contract to cover the majority of the requirements, serving as the main interface between the Collection managers to the Space based ISR tasking and access capability.

4. Envisaged Contractual Relationship

- a. As stated in the Objectives section, the Agency envisages the ISR Collection Orchestration Service capability to be provided by the successful Contractor in any subsequent NATO Competitive Procurement procedure.
- b. Nevertheless, in provision of the Services, the NCIA will require flexibility from the Contractor to:
 - i. Facilitate access to niche data streams and/or advanced AI (based) capabilities from Third Parties, and integrate this data, through the Contractor's sub-contracting commercial arrangements.
 - ii. Ingest datasets provided by NATO for utility in the front-end platform.

5. Performance Requirements

- a. System uptime $\geq 99.5\%$
- b. Incident Priority restoration times

	P0	P1	P2	P3	P4
Response Target Time durations from incident opening to assigned – work in progress status	30mins Wall clock	1h Wall clock	1h During Business Hours 2h Outside Business	9h Business hours or 1 working day	18 Business hours or 2 working days
Restore Target Time durations from incident opening to service restored (Irrespective of fault resolution)	1h Wall Clock	4h Wall clock	8h Wall Clock 9h business hours	18 Business hours or 2 working days	27 Business Hours or 3 working days

6. Deliverables

Deliverable	Description	Frequency	Format
Training	User training	Initially in bulk for all users and as required	Dedicated online sessions or on demand training courses through the tool
Training	Administrator training	Initially for all administrations and as required	Dedicated online sessions or on demand training courses through the tool
Documentation	User and administrator documentation	Updated as required	Online manuals or documentation to support training as required

7. Purchaser Furnished Equipment (PFE) / Information (PFI)

- a. Nil – cloud-based service requested

8. Period of Performance

- a. 3-year period with the option to extend if required.

9. Place of Performance

- a. Cloud based solution required for access by global NATO users.

Annex C – RFI Questions

In order for the NCIA to gain a greater understanding of market-leading Open Source Intelligence Processing Capabilities, please provide responses to the following questions in your response:

Question Number	Question
1	Please provide the following company information: - Legal business name - Address - Website - Primary point of contact - Email address - Size of organisation, including employee headcount and overall scale of operations.
2	Please provide any comments that you have on the High-Level Requirements in Annex B, including: - Risks, concerns, or barriers - Suggestions for risk mitigation or enhancing competition - Any innovations or alternatives - Clarification requests.
3	Please provide a summary of your relevant capabilities, in relation to the scope of the High-Level Requirements stated in Annex B, Including: - Coordination of data streams for collection planning and tasking - Data analysis techniques available on your platform - API availability and speed of integration
4	Please provide a summary of your company's past experience of delivering similar Services to customers operating in highly-regulated environments, e.g. police, defence
5	Please provide a summary of how your organisation maintains the security of its services, including technical, operational, and organisational controls. Where applicable, please reference any industry-recognised security standards or certifications.

6	Please explain your costing model and provide a ROM (considering any assumptions) for the envisioned Services, including: - Licensing costs for 20 users via a cloud-based service - Licensing costs for access to data through APIs.
7	Please outline your pricing model for surge or incremental usage – such as scalability for crisis operations or options for Nations - including: - If applicable, cost per additional licence above the 20-user baseline - Any volume-based pricing tiers or discounts - Minimum or maximum licence thresholds - The process and timelines for increasing or decreasing licence volumes.
8	Please describe your approach to the use of subcontractors or third parties in the delivery of the proposed solution and services, including, how security, compliance, and confidentiality requirements are applied to subcontractors.
9	Please outline whether you can integrate new and/or niche data streams/advanced AI modelling into your interface at the request of a customer, as additional services.
	Please outline your approach to training, whether instructor-led or self paced.

Annex D – Distribution List

1. NATO Delegation (Attn: Investment Adviser)

- | | | |
|-------------|---------------------|--------------------|
| 1. Albania | 12. Greece | 23. Poland |
| 2. Belgium | 13. Hungary | 24. Portugal |
| 3. Bulgaria | 14. Iceland | 25. Romania |
| 4. Canada | 15. Italy | 26. Slovakia |
| 5. Croatia | 16. Latvia | 27. Slovenia |
| 6. Czechia | 17. Lithuania | 28. Spain |
| 7. Denmark | 18. Luxembourg | 29. Sweden |
| 8. Estonia | 19. Montenegro | 30. Türkiye |
| 9. Finland | 20. Netherlands | 31. United Kingdom |
| 10. France | 21. North Macedonia | 32. United States |
| 11. Germany | 22. Norway | |

2. All NATEXs